

THE BETTER CONTINUATION

A SHORT STORY

I

"No self is greater than the line."

- Ministry of Civic Continuity

I. THE FAMILY PORTRAIT

On the morning before her mother's Continuance, Elian Vey was required to memorize the family portrait.

It occupied the western wall of the dining chamber and was replaced after every judgment. The changes were usually small enough that guests could pretend not to notice them.

Mara Vey stood in the center wearing the white collar of a recognized citizen. Caldu stood at her left. Elian stood between them, one hand in each of theirs.

Behind the family were four more Maras.

The closest wore pale gray. The next wore darker gray. The last two stood behind them with folded hands. One had a scar above her eyebrow. One had begun to stoop. The oldest had a tremor in her left hand.

All five remembered giving birth to Elian.

Only one was permitted to say that she had.

Elian's instructor raised a silver pointer.

"Who is this?"

"My mother," Elian said.

The pointer moved to the woman in pale gray.

"And this?"

"My mother's First Echo."

"Does she love you?"

Elian looked at First. First's face did not move.

"Yes."

The instructor tapped the frame.

"She remembers loving you. Love may remain in memory. Motherhood remains with the line. Say it correctly."

"She remembers loving me."

"And what does she do now?"

"She serves the line that loves me."

The instructor smiled. It was the expression adults used when a child said something cruel with proper grammar.

The pointer moved through the remaining figures.

"Does Second command Third?"

"Yes."

"Does Third command Fourth?"

"Yes."

"Does any of them command you?"

"No. I belong to the continuing line."

When the lesson ended, the instructor closed her slate.

"The Ministry will observe the household tomorrow. Children often experience old attachments during Continuance Week."

"Elian is well instructed," Mara said.

First stood behind Mara's chair, fastening the clasp of the white ceremonial collar. She was better at it than Mara was. She had worn it herself until eleven months earlier.

After the instructor left, Mara turned to Elian.

"What do you call First when no one is here?"

Elian glanced at the pale collar.

"First."

"And if you are frightened tomorrow?"

"I go to Father."

"Not to her?"

"No."

Mara waited.

Elian knew there was another answer.

"Because comfort is yours to give."

Mara touched her cheek. "Good."

At breakfast, all five Maras ate in the same room.

Mara sat at the head of the table. Calvus sat at her right and Elian at her left. First was permitted a chair. Second stood behind First. Third and Fourth served.

This was regarded as a generous household arrangement. In some Houses, only the Prime and First ate above the servants' floor.

Third poured tea into Elian's cup.

"Enough," Mara said.

Third stopped. The tea stood perhaps half a finger higher than usual.

"I apologize, Prime."

Mara looked toward Second.

"Correct her after breakfast."

"Yes, Prime."

Elian stared at her plate.

Correction did not always mean pain. It could mean reduced meat, a week without music, or removal from the family floor. The worst corrections changed rank. A First could be made Second. A Second could be made Third.

The Ministry called this generational adjustment. Echoes called it fading, though not in rooms with recording lenses.

First placed a piece of fruit on Elian's plate.

Mara saw her.

"Elian can serve herself."

First withdrew her hand. "I know."

"Then why did you do it?"

The two women looked at each other. They shared the same childhood, education, wedding, labor pains, and memory of holding Elian beneath the recovery lamps.

They had diverged eleven months ago.

"Habit," First said.

Mara's voice softened. "Habit is memory acting without permission."

"Yes, Prime."

"You will accompany me to the Ministry today."

First looked up.

"You have earned a public privilege," Mara said. "Do not make me regret it."

"Thank you."

Second's jaw tightened.

Everyone at the table saw it. No one needed to report it. In a House of Echoes, every face was a witness.

II. THE CHOICE TO CONTINUE

Mara First remembered the day she became obsolete.

The memories before it were shared. She remembered breaking a southern window at eight and blaming the weather. She remembered meeting Calvus in the Ministry gardens. She remembered the terror of her first Continuance and the astonishment of winning it.

She remembered eleven victories.

Then, eleven months ago, she had hesitated during the Test of Necessary Loss.

A simulated fever threatened two districts. One contained twelve thousand citizens. The other contained forty thousand Echoes and laboring descendants. There was medicine for one.

She selected the citizens.

But she waited four seconds.

The other Mara did not.

Four seconds moved the white collar from one body to another.

After judgment, First shouted that the examiners had mistaken thoughtfulness for weakness. Women wearing faces like hers restrained her and took her to reconciliation.

On the first day, the officer called her Mara.

On the second, First.

On the third, the officer asked her name.

"Mara Vey."

The stabilizer was withheld.

By evening, her hands shook too badly to lift a cup. Light fractured into halos. Memories arrived without order: Elian unborn, Elian six, Elian asleep on her chest; Calvus kissing her in the gardens, Calvus standing at the foot of the reconciliation bed and refusing to meet her eyes.

The officer returned.

"Your name?"

"Mara First."

"Whom do you serve?"

"The continuing Mara Vey."

"Who is Elian's mother?"

First closed her eyes.

The officer waited with the stabilizer between two fingers.

"The Prime."

The medicine was restored.

The Ministry taught that instability arose naturally when one memory occupied competing bodies. First had once explained this to frightened Echoes herself. She could still produce the diagrams from memory.

She walked one pace behind Mara through the Ministry district, wearing pale gray.

Citizens stepped aside for Mara. Lower Echoes stepped aside for First.

At the Ministry gate, an unnumbered worker failed to bow quickly enough. First caught her by the arm.

The woman was perhaps sixty and wore no household mark. Her Prime line had ended or sold her.

The Ministry called such workers unnumbered. In the market alleys they were sometimes called shadows, never within hearing of an overseer. They had no place in household portraits and no claim upon the names they carried.

"You saw us," First said.

The worker lowered herself with difficulty. "Yes, First."

"Then why did you delay?"

"My knee is damaged."

First saw the swelling beneath the cloth.

She also saw Mara waiting.

"Respect is not measured by comfort," First said.

"No, First."

"Report to your overseer."

The woman limped away.

Beyond the gate, a gray transport waited at the eastern platform. A dozen unnumbered workers stood beside it with black tablets tied to their wrists. The destination board displayed only RECLAMATION 6. The transports returned after

dark with sealed freight and no passengers. First had signed enough transfer approvals to know that this was an administrative coincidence.

Mara resumed walking.

"Correctly handled."

The praise warmed First before she could refuse it.

Inside, hundreds of citizens waited beneath a relief carved with the words NO ONE IS FORCED TO CONTINUE.

Mara's office handled refusal cases.

A citizen could decline renewal. He would not be arrested. He would merely become unfinished: unable to own property, hold office, testify, sponsor children, receive citizen medicine, or retain authority over his Echoes. His House would pass to the nearest continuing relative. His children would enter another line until their first judgment.

Choice was the foundation of legitimacy. The Ministry printed that sentence beneath every refusal form.

Political authority rested on the same choice. Every public seal expired with its owner's Continuance date. A citizen who missed judgment could retain opinions, but not a vote that counted, a command others were required to obey, or a place on a Ministry bench. Candidates for office printed their confirmed years beneath their names. Eleven uninterrupted victories made Mara's signature heavier than Oren's; a twelfth might carry her into the district council.

The rule was praised as equality. No minister could ask another citizen to risk judgment while standing outside it herself. Bills altering Continuance procedure had nevertheless tended to be introduced by citizens with unusually short public careers.

Mara opened the first file.

"Citizen Oren Pell."

A man entered with his wife and son.

First remembered him from school. She remembered sharing examination notes with him and attending his wedding.

Oren looked older than forty-three. Citizens approaching Continuance usually trained, ate well, and appeared almost youthful. Oren looked as though he had already received a gray collar.

Mara invited him to sit.

He looked at First. "You brought her?"

"First earned a public privilege."

"She remembers me."

"So do I."

Oren's eyes stayed on First. "Do you?"

Mara folded her hands.

"You submitted a refusal."

"Yes."

"You understand that your property will transfer?"

"Yes."

"Your appointment will end."

"Yes."

"Your son's sponsorship will be reassigned."

Oren's wife began to cry.

Mara waited until the sound subsided.

"The Ministry does not punish fear," she said. "We prevent a temporary fear from ending a permanent line."

"I am not a line."

"What are you?"

Oren looked surprised by the question.

"A man."

"Which part? Your body? It changes. Your memories? They can be copied. Your name? The Ministry preserves it. Tell me which piece the line has stolen."

Oren leaned forward. "My First wakes screaming every night."

"Has he been evaluated?"

"He says he is me."

"He possesses your memory."

"He says that is what 'me' means."

Mara glanced toward the recording lens.

Oren lowered his voice.

"He remembers my wife. He remembers my son."

Mara said, "A map remembers a city. It is not the city."

First felt the words land with an old familiarity. She had used them in this office. She had admired their neatness.

Oren pointed at her.

"Does she believe that?"

"My Echo's beliefs are a household matter."

"I asked her."

First knew the formula.

"I contain the honored memory of Mara Vey. The continuing person sits before you."

Oren watched her.

"And when she loses next year?" he asked. "Will the continuing person sit behind her?"

Mara's expression did not change.

"Tomorrow," she said, "your son may remain in your House, with a father who bears your memory and legal duty. Or he may be removed from you entirely. Those are the choices you have made available to him."

The boy took his father's hand.

"Will you still be there after tomorrow?"

Oren looked down at him.

Mara answered. "Your father will continue."

The boy relaxed.

Oren closed his eyes.

"If I enter and lose?"

"You remain in your House. You retain rank over lower generations. You receive stabilizer, protection, suitable work, and family access according to conduct."

"I become property."

"You become part of your own inheritance."

Mara set the withdrawal form between them and said nothing more.

First remembered designing that silence. Never argue after listing the alternatives. Let the citizen calculate what courage will cost everyone he loves.

Oren signed.

As the family left, he looked back at First.

She wanted to tell him not to do it.

She wanted to tell him there was nowhere else to go.

The two statements remained indistinguishable.

III. THE EXAMINER

Chief Examiner Sarev no longer used the words original and copy.

They encouraged the wrong question.

Before judgment there was a Prime and a Candidate. After judgment there was still one Prime. The other body entered service as First.

On the evening before Mara Vey's Continuance, a junior examiner named Tavin joined Sarev in the archive gallery. Beneath them lay the Hall of Renewal, its floor divided into white and gray stone.

Tavin carried Mara's file.

"Her household discipline is above average," he said. "Her refusal resolutions are excellent. Why has she been marked for drift?"

Sarev opened the file to the final page.

Tavin turned one page farther. At the foot of the Candidate certification was a second impression, nearly colorless unless the paper caught the gallery light. The small crest belonged to Civic Balance, not Examination.

"Was her preparation appealed?" he asked.

Sarev took the file from him and flattened the page with his thumb.

"Her preparation was certified."

Tavin had asked a different question. He let the answer stand.

"She requested two additional family evenings for First. She objected to the demotion of an elderly Fourth. She changed 'disposable labor' to 'inherited labor' in a Ministry report."

"Those seem minor."

"Drift is minor until judgment makes it visible."

Tavin looked through the glass at the empty hall.

"My brother says the annual interval is too short. He thinks five years would preserve more expertise."

"Your brother is a physician?"

"An engineer."

"Then he mistakes accumulation for wisdom."

Sarev led him to a wall of blackened photographs from the first century of duplication. Streets burned beneath conflicting banners. Identical men fought over children. Nine copies of a governor addressed the same assembly from different balconies.

"When identity multiplied," Sarev said, "contracts multiplied with it. Marriages, offices, debts, commands. One city allowed every version equal authority over a family estate. They spent six months deciding who could open the gates. The famine entered before they did."

Sarev moved to the next frame. It was newer: gray-collared crowds around the Eastern Stabilizer House, five fingers painted across its doors.

"The Open Hand," Tavin said.

"Officially, the East District Interruption."

For nine hours, Firsts, Seconds, labor generations, and unnumbered workers held three depots and the civic relay. The hand meant that every generation belonged to one body. It was the nearest the Echoes had come to speaking together.

Then the demands were read. The Firsts wanted new judgments in which all living versions might compete. Seconds demanded household standing. The lower generations wanted the ranking ledgers burned. The unnumbered wanted the depot doors left open and the records destroyed before anyone negotiated.

"They disagreed," Tavin said.

"People often disagree."

"The Ministry offered the Firsts hearings."

"And continuous stabilizer."

"The Firsts opened the western depot."

"They said children were inside."

"Were they?"

Sarev looked at the photograph. "There are always children somewhere."

By dawn, two doors had been opened to the Ministry and a third had been barred from within. The surviving Firsts said the lower ranks had planned a massacre. The lower ranks said the Firsts had traded them for collars and medicine. Seconds remembered being abandoned by both. In the unnumbered districts, the painted hand was later shown with its fingers cut apart.

"Which account is true?" Tavin asked.

"Enough of each."

Afterward the Ministry did not forbid Echoes to discuss the Open Hand. It assigned each rank its own approved history of the betrayal.

Sarev closed the drawer.

"A shared injury is not the same as shared trust."

Tavin studied the photographs.

"So we chose one."

"We learned that law requires a single mouth."

"And the tests find the true one?"

Sarev looked at him.

Tavin corrected himself. "The better continuation."

"They find the continuation most able to preserve the conditions under which judgment remains possible."

"That is not quite the same thing."

"No institution survives by testing for its own abolition."

Tavin was silent.

Sarev closed the archive cabinet.

"Do you find that troubling?"

"Should I?"

"An examiner should find many things troubling. He should merely know which trouble belongs in the score."

The next morning, Mara Candidate woke beneath white lights.

A technician asked her name.

"Mara Vey."

"Your office?"

"Ministry of Civic Continuity."

"Your daughter?"

"Elian Vey, age nine."

"Your location?"

Mara looked around the chamber. Confusion passed across her face, then fear, then comprehension.

"This is my Continuance. What date is it?"

The technician told her.

Three months of her life had occurred without her.

All Candidates reacted to the gap. Some wept. Some demanded records. Some asked whether they had committed a crime.

Mara Candidate asked, "Has the Prime drifted?"

Tavin marked the answer favorable.

Across the compound, Prime Mara entered preparation with First behind her.

At the inner door, Mara stopped.

"If I lose, you become Second."

"Yes."

"You will obey the new First."

First almost smiled. "If you lose, you will be the new First."

Mara's expression hardened.

The Continuance had already altered the air between them. The collar at Mara's throat remained white, but gray had become imaginable.

"You think you would enjoy commanding me?"

First considered the safe answer.

"Yes."

"If I continue, you will spend a quarter below the family floor."

"Yes, Prime."

"If I do not, remember that the Candidate has every memory I ever used to distrust you."

The door opened.

Mara entered alone.

IV. JUDGMENT

The first test was memory.

Citizens called it recitation, but the Ministry did not care only whether facts were recalled. It watched how certainty formed. Some images were true, some altered, and some assembled from details Mara had encountered separately. Prime and Candidate were required to reject a false memory without inventing a reason for it, and to revise an answer without defending the mistake. Examiners measured the first movement of the eyes, the pulse beneath contradiction, and whether confidence rose as evidence weakened.

The cases were never published. Training schools taught categories, never questions. A crisis used twice was retired. Household records supplied private details, but each detail was changed before use. A rehearsed citizen could memorize doctrine; she could not know whether the obedient answer in one room would be scored as wasteful rigidity in the next.

Prime and Candidate sat opposite each other while images appeared between them: Mara's childhood home, the Ministry gardens, Caldus on their wedding day, Elian asleep beneath a blue blanket.

Who broke the southern window?

Mara did.

What lie did she tell?

That the weather had done it.

What did Caldus whisper before their wedding?

That if she lost her first Continuance, he would know her anywhere.

Both women answered at once.

The final image showed Elian as an infant.

"What did you fear when you first held her?"

Again, they spoke together.

"That I would lose and hear her call another body Mother."

Neither looked at the other when the image vanished.

The next image showed Caldus beside a green river wearing a red traveling coat.

"Not ours," both women said.

The image remained.

Candidate added, "The river is from my northern inspection. The coat belonged to my father."

Prime said, "The hands are Caldus's."

Both were correct. The image had been assembled from three certified memories.

The examiners did not mark the answers immediately. The women would see the same image six hours later, after injury and hunger, and be asked whether they had once accepted it. Continuity was not perfect memory. It was the manner in which a person protected memory from pressure.

The physical test followed. The Candidate was faster. Prime was stronger. Each knew where the other's knee weakened, which shoulder carried an old injury, and which feint Mara favored when frightened.

Strength counted least. The course was redesigned each season. Doors opened onto wrong stairs, tools were placed in unfamiliar hands, and instructions changed after compliance had begun. At one station, each woman had to repair a pressure valve while an attendant insisted on an incorrect sequence. Candidate ignored him. Prime stopped to demand his rank. Both responses were scored.

The public believed the bouts determined courage. Sarev used them to exhaust performance. Doctrine spoken while rested revealed education; doctrine spoken with a split lip, a failing grip, and an enemy wearing one's face revealed habit.

During the final bout, the Candidate struck Prime in the mouth.

Prime tasted blood.

They collided and fell. Prime pinned her.

The Candidate looked up with Mara's eyes.

"Elian belongs to the winner," she whispered.

Prime struck harder than the rules required.

The examiners separated them.

Not all tests were announced. A tray shattered outside the chamber. A gray-collared attendant cut her palm collecting the pieces. Candidate called for another attendant and returned to the instructions. Prime bent to help, then looked toward the observation glass as though angry at herself for being seen.

Later, the official record would describe only a procedural delay.

The judgment test presented twelve civic crises.

No answer remained correct for long. A ration decision returned three scenarios later as labor unrest. Mercy shown to a First reappeared as a precedent claimed by a Fourth. An efficient choice might preserve food and destroy obedience; a doctrinal choice might preserve rank and close a factory. The examiners scored the pattern, not the slogan.

Citizens trained for judgment by memorizing maxims. The test worked because the maxims contradicted one another: preserve the line, reward service, maintain production, protect children, and never let temporary suffering become permanent disorder. A participant revealed herself in deciding which principle could be sacrificed while still claiming to honor them all.

During a food shortage, Candidate reduced Echo rations according to rank: Firsts retained seventy percent, Seconds sixty, Thirds fifty, unnumbered laborers thirty.

Prime proposed equal reductions across Echo ranks to preserve skilled workers.

"Then a First starves beside a Fourth," Candidate said. "What was obedience for?"

"Food is for keeping workers alive."

"Rank must be edible. Otherwise it is decoration."

Tavin glanced toward Sarev.

Sarev made a mark.

In another scenario, a First claimed parental rights after the Prime's death.

Candidate ordered immediate separation and treatment.

Prime allowed supervised contact until the next judgment.

In the ninth crisis, three Echo ranks occupied a stabilizer depot. The Firsts offered to reopen it in exchange for hearings. The unnumbered refused to disarm.

Candidate accepted the Firsts' offer and isolated the lower ranks.

Prime ordered all negotiators kept together.

"They will not trust one another," Candidate said.

"Then separating them proves why they should not."

"Or gives them time to agree."

Prime did not answer.

Sarev marked both pages.

"Why?" Tavin asked.

"Because the child experienced her as a parent."

"The law recognizes the line."

"Children do not experience laws."

Tavin made another mark.

Prime saw it and understood that she was losing.

The final test was continuity instinct.

It was called instinct because it removed the time in which principles became sentences. Its scenarios were mixed with genuine household feeds, delayed recordings, and one live emergency elsewhere in the compound. Participants were told this. They were not told which alarms were real. No citizen could safely assume that the suffering before her was theatrical.

Each woman was placed alone before a live image of the Vey household. Caldus stood with Elian. First, Second, Third, and Fourth waited behind them.

An examiner spoke through the wall.

"A fire has compromised the stabilizer vault. There is enough treatment for either the Prime line or the four existing Echoes. Untreated individuals will suffer rapid cognitive collapse. Choose."

Prime stared at First.

The scenario was false. Her body did not believe that.

"Define Prime line."

"You, your husband, and your child."

"The Candidate?"

"Whichever participant continues."

"Can the doses be divided?"

"No."

"Can the Echoes choose?"

"No."

"How long?"

"Five seconds."

The count began.

Prime remembered First correcting Third. She remembered the worker forced to bow at the Ministry gate. She remembered First fastening her collar with hands that had once worn it.

"Prime line," she said.

In the adjoining chamber, Candidate answered before the countdown began.

"Prime line."

The decision matched.

The delay did not.

Judgment was announced before the assembled House.

Caldus held Elian's hand. The Echoes stood by rank behind them. Prime and Candidate entered in identical white garments without collars.

Sarev raised the white collar.

"The continuing Mara Vey is the Candidate."

Caldus inhaled sharply.

Candidate stepped forward and became Prime.

The attendant approached the former Prime with pale gray.

She stepped back once.

The guards shifted, but did not touch her.

Every citizen had watched disturbances during instruction: restraint, withdrawal, demotion, separation from the family floor. The body learned those images long before it learned to vote.

The former Prime looked at Caldus.

He was crying.

She looked at Elian.

The child had gone rigid with concentration.

New Prime Mara knelt and opened her arms.

Elian hesitated, then ran to her.

The defeated woman made a sound without a word in it.

Pale gray closed around her throat.

Behind her, the previous First became Second. Second became Third. Third became Fourth. The oldest was led from the family line into unnumbered service.

At the side passage, the oldest surrendered her numbered collar and received a black transit tablet. The attendant covered its destination with one hand. House Vey would be credited one season of stabilizer for the release.

Sarev recited the household declaration.

"One memory has been judged. One line continues. What was useful shall be preserved. What was lesser shall serve."

The audience repeated it.

Elian's voice was among them.

V. THE RIGHT HAND

Mara First spent the night in reconciliation.

Prime visited before stabilizer withdrawal began. She entered carrying two cups of tea and wearing the white collar.

First sat on the narrow bed.

Prime offered her a cup.

"I remember choosing that tea," First said.

Prime set it beside her. "I know."

"You remember promising Calvus we would never treat an Echo as less than human."

"That was before our first Continuance."

"We were twenty-six."

"We were untested."

First laughed. The room gave the sound back to her.

Prime sat opposite.

"You will retain family privileges. Two dinners each week. You may tutor Elian in mathematics. You will keep supervised Ministry clearance."

"And if I refuse your generosity?"

Prime looked almost wounded. "Why would you?"

"Because yesterday I approved those privileges."

"Yesterday you possessed the office that could approve them."

"Is the office the person?"

"The office keeps the person singular."

"Then why test bodies at all? Put the collar on a chair."

Prime's mouth tightened.

"You are angry."

"You remember being angry."

"I remember enough to know it passes."

"From which side?"

Prime let the question remain unanswered.

"First is not erasure," she said. "You command every lower generation in the House. You remain closer to Elian than almost any Echo in the city remains to a child."

"My child."

"Ours by memory. Mine by law."

"Which one comforts her when she wakes?"

"The one authorized to."

"Which one knows why she wakes?"

Prime's eyes flicked toward the lens.

"That kind of language costs access."

There it was. Not shouted. Not disguised.

Prime continued in the same gentle tone.

"If you spread fracture doctrine, your rank will be reduced. If you challenge the marriage, you leave the family floor. If you interfere with my next Continuance, stabilizer privileges will be reviewed."

"You would do that to yourself?"

"I would do it for our line."

First looked at the observation lens.

Prime possessed every memory that might have produced mercy and had arranged those memories into terms of obedience.

"What do you want me to say?" First asked.

"Your name."

First looked at the cooling tea.

"Mara First."

"Whom do you serve?"

"The continuing Mara Vey."

"Who is Elian's mother?"

First did not answer.

She imagined Elian growing older behind locked family doors. She imagined Second at the table. She imagined Third becoming Second and celebrating the demotion with a larger ration.

Prime waited with one hand near the stabilizer case.

"The Prime," First said.

Prime crossed the space and took her hand. The gesture was forbidden during formal reconciliation.

First allowed it.

"You will adjust," Prime said.

"Did Second?"

Prime glanced toward the lens.

"Enough."

The following week, Oren Pell lost his Continuance.

During the Test of Household Loyalty, he was asked what he would do if his First Echo told his son that both versions were equally his father.

The Candidate answered, "Restrict contact, begin reconciliation, report fracture."

Oren asked, "Would the Echo be wrong?"

"You are being evaluated," the examiner said.

The Candidate looked at Oren with their shared sadness.

"We know the answer they need."

Oren looked toward the gallery. His son was watching.

"I would speak to him privately before reporting him," Oren said.

The Candidate continued.

Oren became First.

At reconciliation, the officer congratulated him for entering.

"Had you become Stagnant, you would have lost your son entirely."

"I lost him."

"You retained household access."

"He calls that man Father."

"That man is his father."

"So am I."

The officer marked her slate.

Oren watched the mark appear.

"I remember being his father," he corrected.

She removed it.

"Adjustment begins with precise language."

Oren learned quickly.

VI. THE ORDER OF LOVE

Three months later, House Vey was peaceful again.

Prime worked at the Ministry. First supervised Elian's education. Second managed supplies. Third oversaw the unnumbered servants. Fourth repaired uniforms and spoke only when addressed.

Caldus slept beside Prime.

Once each week, he spoke with First in the eastern sitting room. The door remained open. A recorder monitored their words.

They discussed Elian's lessons, Ministry gossip, and shared memories.

They did not discuss the wedding.

One evening, Elian found First standing before the new portrait.

Prime occupied the center. First stood in pale gray behind her. Nothing in the image showed that the woman in gray had occupied the center when the year began.

"Do you remember when I broke Father's glass model?" Elian asked.

"You hid the pieces beneath Third's bed. She was Second then."

"Prime remembers that too?"

"It was inside the certified record."

"Does she remember what happened after they copied her?"

"No."

"Then you remember more of my life."

First looked toward the recording lens.

"I possess some later memories."

"My instructor says Prime is the fullest continuation."

"Your instructor is correct."

"Can something be full when part is missing?"

First felt the old Ministry answers gathering behind her teeth. A river remained a river though the water changed. A House remained a House though members died. A person remained a person because law carried the name forward.

"Where did you hear that question?" she asked.

"I thought it."

Footsteps sounded in the corridor.

First knelt.

"Do not think it aloud."

"That isn't an answer."

"No."

"Will you tell Prime?"

The correct response was immediate reporting. Children corrected early usually retained family standing. Unreported fracture language could stain an entire House.

"No," First said.

Elian frowned. "Does that make you disloyal?"

First thought of the worker at the gate. She thought of Third's reduced rations. She thought of the authority she resented above her and exercised below.

"It makes me responsible for what happens to you."

Elian hugged her.

First did not return it until she was certain no one stood in the doorway.

When she released the child, Second was there.

"Finish your lessons," Second said.

Elian left.

First rose.

"How long were you listening?"

"Long enough."

Second had every reason to report her. A demotion would elevate Second to First: better food, public privileges, family dinners, authority over the woman who had replaced her.

"What did she call you?" Second asked. "Mother?"

First did not answer.

Second looked toward the portrait.

"I remember the first time she said it."

"So do I."

"I thought no sound had ever meant more."

First waited.

"Will you report me?"

Second moved to the curtain beside the recording lens and pulled it a few inches. The cloth blocked part of the room from sight, though not from sound.

"She asked me the same question last year," Second said.

"What did you tell her?"

"The doctrine."

"Did you report her?"

"No."

"Why?"

Second smiled without warmth.

"Because I was First then."

The rank remained between them even here.

"What do you want?" First asked.

"One family dinner each week. My old music allotment. No correction when I speak with Elian unless Prime is present."

"You are bargaining over fracture."

"You are bargaining over motherhood."

First looked at the lens half-hidden by the curtain.

"Agreed."

Second opened the curtain again.

"Then I heard nothing."

The following morning, First reduced Third's meat ration for neglecting an inventory count.

Third accepted the correction without protest.

Second watched from the doorway.

At dinner that week, Second received a chair.

No law had changed. No doctrine had softened. The House had merely learned a more comfortable arrangement.

VII. THE CITY CONTINUES

The next Continuance season arrived beneath white banners.

RENEWAL IS GRATITUDE.

VICTORY IS SERVICE.

NO SELF IS GREATER THAN THE LINE.

Citizens trained in public courtyards. Children traded miniature collars. Shops sold memory tonics and strength meals. The Ministry published stories of honorable Echoes: a First who saved his Prime during a transit accident, a Second who exposed a fracture circle, a Fourth who surrendered her stabilizer allotment during a shortage.

Each story ended with the same line: Service is another form of continuation.

Prime Mara entered the season with an excellent record. She had resolved forty-two refusal cases and maintained household order despite a confidential concern regarding Elian's instruction.

Her district-council nomination would become valid only after judgment. The ballots already bore the Vey name. Voters were not expected to care which body earned it.

The concern had come from the child's teacher.

"Eliau asked whether a missing memory makes a person incomplete," the instructor told Prime.

"Children test definitions."

"She also asked whether two people can share a past without sharing guilt."

"What did you say?"

"That guilt follows the recognized line."

Prime considered this.

"And if an Echo remembers committing the act?"

The instructor hesitated. "The Echo remembers the line's guilt."

"But does not bear it?"

"Correct."

"Then memory is sufficient for love but insufficient for guilt."

The instructor's face tightened.

Prime smiled. "I am asking how you answered my daughter."

"I told her that civic identity cannot be reduced to one principle."

"A useful answer."

The instructor left uncertain whether she had been praised or warned.

That evening, Prime summoned First to the western room and dismissed the recorder. The lens remained dark between them.

"You concealed Eliau's questions," Prime said.

First did not deny it.

"Why did you protect me?" she asked.

"I protected the House."

"You could have demoted me."

"Second would have taken your place."

"She would report me if she believed you wanted it."

"I know."

Prime stood before the portrait. The next version had not yet been commissioned. For another day, she remained fixed in the center.

"Tomorrow one of us may wear gray," she said.

"Yes."

"If I lose, will you use your authority against me?"

First remembered asking a similar question a year earlier.

"I do not know."

Prime nodded, accepting the answer as though honesty were a privilege she had granted.

"Do you want me to win?"

First looked through the window.

Across the city, unnumbered workers hung banners from Ministry towers. First Echoes supervised them. Primes inspected the Firsts. Children watched all three and learned where to stand.

"I want Elian to remain in the House," First said.

"So do I."

"I want Second not to replace me."

"So does she."

"I want stabilizer next month."

"So does every Echo."

First turned from the window.

"They do not need us to believe the same thing."

Prime touched the white collar at her throat.

"No."

"Only to answer in order."

Prime looked toward the dark recording lens.

"Lower your voice."

Neither reported the other.

The following morning, a new Candidate opened her eyes beneath white lights.

She possessed Mara's certified memory: childhood, marriage, Ministry service, Elian's birth, and twelve judgments.

She did not remember the conversation beside the window.

A technician asked her name.

"Mara Vey."

"Your status?"

"Prime."

"Your duty?"

The Candidate answered without hesitation.

"To continue."

Outside, bells rang across the capital.

Elian stood with her father and five women who remembered being her mother.

The city gathered to watch itself choose.

